eyed person, and the Indian press referred to him as ‘One-Eyed Jack’, from a classic Western movie by Marlon Brando.

His real name, however, was Chandrasekharampillai Packiachandran, and he hailed from Udupiddy, a small town 32 km from Jaffna city and about 3 km off Prabhakaran’s home town, Valvettithurai, the epicentre of Tamil armed militancy. His father, Chandrasekharampillai, used to teach the English language in a missionary school in Udupiddy. His mother, Sivapackiyam, also hailed from the Jaffna peninsula. He was named after his parents—‘Packia’ from his mother and ‘Chandran’ from his father. He inculcated Tamil nationalist feelings at a very young age, thanks to his father, as per reports by the Sri Lankan military. He started supporting the Tamil United Liberation Front (TULF) from that time.[11]

He was known to be a smart student with an aptitude for languages. He passed examinations with flying colours. The early death of his father in 1977 compelled him to drop out of school and take on the family’s financial responsibility. Among his jobs was a stint with the state electricity board in Trincomalee and another at Batticaloa in the Eastern Province. Around that time, he was arrested for distributing leaflets with pro-Tamil sentiments. In jail, he had reportedly painted prison walls with slogans demanding Tamil liberation. His prison term was extended and he was shifted to the Jaffna Fort Camp prison. Soon, he joined the Tamil Eelam Liberation Organization (TELO).

After joining TELO, Packiachandran left for India to receive training in Kumbakonam, Tamil Nadu. Posted in the propaganda unit of TELO, he interacted with students in Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka. Besides his fluency in the English language, Packiachandran became conversant in other south Indian languages and Hindi. He could even speak Tamil with a Tamil Nadu accent. He returned to Jaffna and joined the LTTE, where he was rechristened ‘Raghuvaran’, or ‘Raghu’. His initial job was that of a money collector. According to some reports, he wouldn’t mind extracting money from people at gunpoint, which led to rising terror around him. On one occasion, according to reports, he snatched dowry money from a wedding and decamped with a large portion of the